lim students are also among the newer ones and were beneficiaries of grants.

Those who run madrasas have their priorities clear. "We have nothing against action being taken madrasas against whom financial irregularities are detected," says Qureshi, who runs a madrasa in the Jinsi area of Bhopal with a student strength of 800. He says many non-Muslims have studied in madrasas and still do so as it is free.

The local media in MP often carry unconfirmed reports about madrasas engaging in subversive activity. "If there are any institutions that are teaching their members to use sticks and swords, action should be taken against them," says Qureshi. However, he denies that any madrasa has been found engaged in "anti-national activity".

"We are carrying out checks on all institutions under various boards of the school education department. Some madrasas existed on paper while some others were not found at their registered addresses. Notices to close down such madrasas have been issued," says MP minister for school education Rao Uday Pratap Singh. He says the objective of the exercise is to ensure quality education. On being asked if any madrasas were found engaging in subversive activities, the minister says, "If a claim like that is made, it should be justified." ■

EDUCATION WATCH

- **The Madhya Pradesh government has asked officials to inspect all government-aided madrasas**
- **They are to find out if non-Muslim students on rolls are admitted without the consent of parents/ guardians**
- **They are also to check if names of students are being put on the rolls fraudulently so that madrasas can claim government aid**



UTTAR PRADESH

RACE FOR THE DA

By Prashant Srivastava

When workers of the Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP) joined the Bharat Bandh called by the Reservation Bachao Sangharsh Samiti on August 21, it was for the first time in eight years that they had taken to the streets. Even as BSP supremo Mayawati was the one to announce the decision, party insiders claim the push came from her nephew Akash Anand. Less than two months after being reinstated as the BSP national coordinator and Mayawati's political heir, Akash is back in the thick of things. When the BSP announced its alliance with the Indian National Lok Dal (INLD) for the Haryana assembly election slated for next month, it was again Akash who addressed the joint press conference in Chandigarh on July 11.

In the ever-evolving political landscape of Uttar Pradesh, the BSP finds itself at a crossroads. Mayawati, known for her iron grip on the party, made a surprising U-turn in June by reinstating her 29-year-old nephew on the posts that he was made to vacate just about a month and a half prior. The decision came on the heels of the party's dismal performance in the Lok Sabha election. The BSP's successive setbacks have created a vacuum in Dalit politics, one that emerging leaders like the 37-year-old Bhim Army chief Chandrashekhar Azad are eager to fill. His victory in the Nagina Lok Sabha seat, securing over 51 per cent of the vote share, has positioned him as a rising star in Bahujan politics.

Meanwhile, Akash's journey in the BSP has been tumultuous. An MBA from London, he was made the party's national coordinator in 2019. Then, in December last year, Mayawati declared him her political heir, following which he had campaigned extensively for the party. But on May 7, in the middle of the general election, Mayawati removed him from his roles, citing a "lack of maturity".